

Rossini moved to Venice, since this was the main operatic center in the northeast. Several of his early operas were performed there but, as his name became better known, he was lured to other cities. This was not just a case of provincial rivalry. Italy had not yet been unified, so these cities belonged to separate states. To complicate matters, Rossini's career coincided with the Napoleonic Wars, when France and Austria were competing for control of the peninsula. Venice, for example, changed hands four times between 1797, when it was conquered by Bonaparte, and 1814, when it was ceded to the Austrians.

Rossini could not fail to be affected by some of these issues. His father had been imprisoned briefly on two occasions for political activities and he himself had come under suspicion from the Austrian police after penning a hymn to independence in 1815. More often, though, any patriotic sentiments were subsumed into the fiction of his compositions. In *L'italiana in Algeri* (The Italian Girl in Algiers), Isabella leads a group of Italian slaves to freedom with a famous aria, "Pensa alla patria" ("Think of the homeland"), following a sly musical reference to the French national anthem, the Marseillaise. Similarly, the plot of *William Tell* revolves around the efforts of a heroic Swiss revolutionary to free his land from its Austrian occupiers.